

MODDABLE CHESS · VARIANT 52 OF 155

Dragon Chess

8×8

BOARD

2

PLAYERS

DRAGON CHESS

Dragon Chess is a chess variant created by Grandmaster Miguel Illescas. The game begins in the standard chess starting position. Each player holds **two Dragon pieces in reserve** and may gate one onto any empty square on their own first rank at any point during the game instead of making a normal move.

THE DRAGON

The **Dragon (D)** moves as a **Bishop combined with a Knight** – it can slide diagonally any number of squares and also jump to any of the 8 Knight destination squares. This piece is known in fairy chess as the **Archbishop** or **Cardinal**. The Dragon is not colourbound (its Knight moves can reach squares of either colour). It is stronger than a Rook but slightly weaker than a Queen in most positions.

SETUP

Standard 8×8 chess starting position. Each player begins with **2 Dragons in reserve** (off the board).

FEN: rnbqkbnr/pppppppp/8/8/8/8/PPPPPPPP/RNBQKBNR [DDdd] w KQkq – 0 1

(D/d = Dragon. [DDdd] = White has 2 Dragons in hand, Black has 2 Dragons in hand.)

RULES

- On any turn, instead of moving a piece on the board, a player may **gate** one of their reserve Dragons onto any **empty square on their own first rank** (rank 1 for White, rank 8 for Black).
- A Dragon cannot be gated onto an occupied square.
- Once gated, a Dragon moves and captures as any other piece on subsequent turns.
- A player may gate their Dragons on any turn – there is no obligation to gate early or late.
- Each player has exactly 2 Dragons for the entire game; once both are on the board, no more gating is possible.
- If a Dragon on the board is captured, it is gone permanently (no return to hand).
- All standard chess rules apply: castling, en passant, promotion (Pawns may promote to Queen, Rook, Bishop, Knight, or Dragon), stalemate is a draw.

ATTRIBUTION

Dragon Chess was created by Grandmaster Miguel Illescas. Rules documented from pychess.org/variants/dragon.